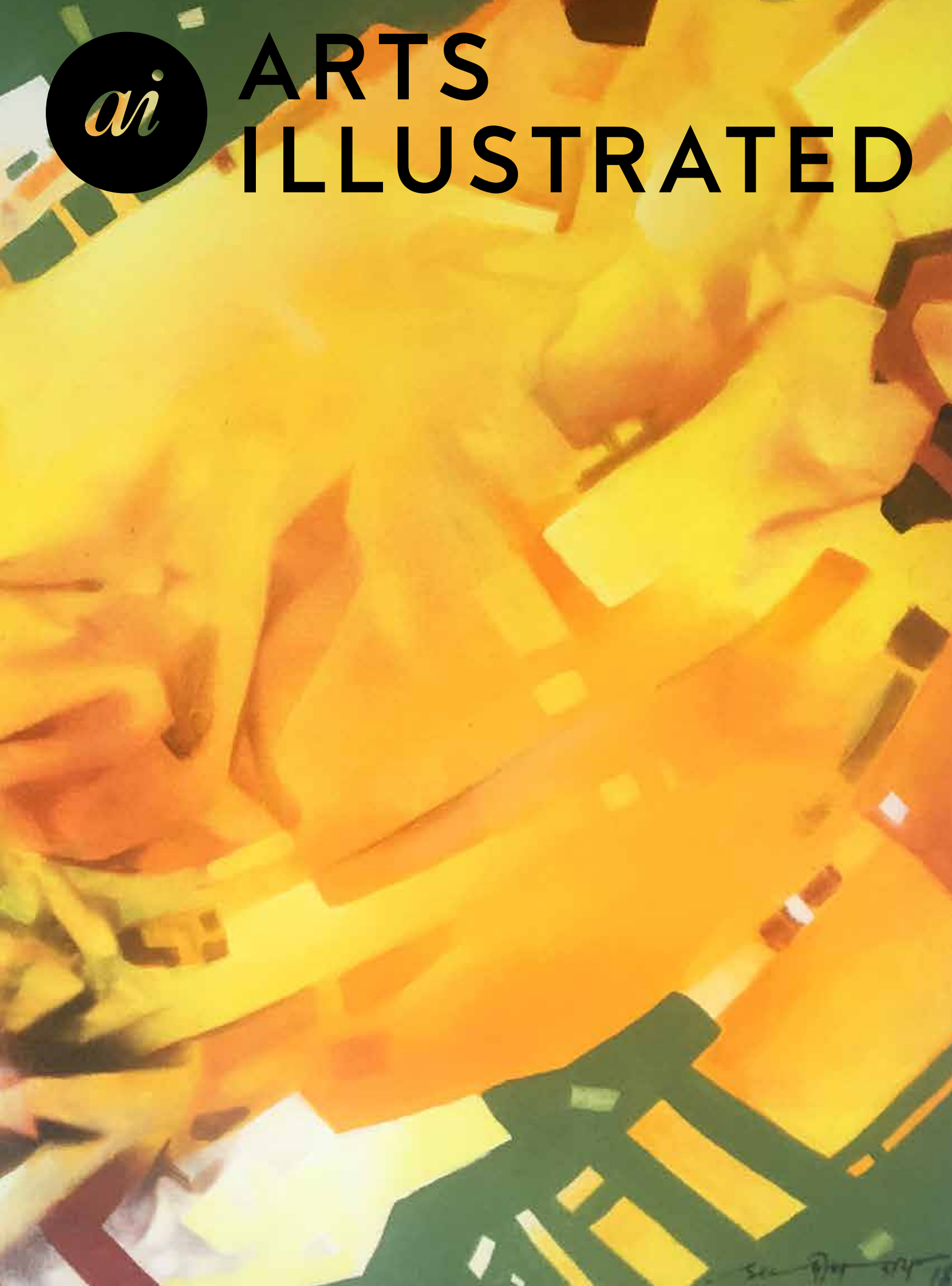




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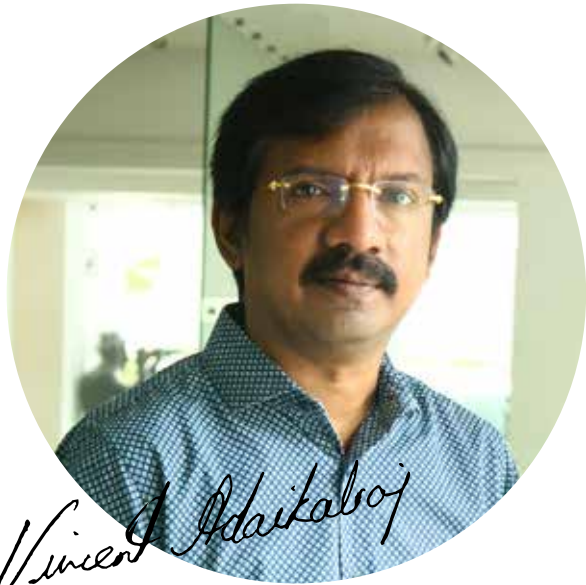
Publisher's note

Arts Illustrated turns five, and so, the theme for this anniversary issue is simply the number '5'. What are the different, quirky, literal, unpredictable, far-fetched, believable ways in which this number of balance can be interpreted? How far is it going to take us; and, more importantly, how delightfully fun is the process going to be?

In the past five years, we have looked at various themes and met artists who gave us surprising perspectives, but one common thread that bound them all together was that we kept the themes relevant to the reality of our times, and that's how we defined the 'contemporary' in the art. With '5', too, no matter how we choose to interpret it, it will continue to deeply question, engage and deliberate over the things that shape our world.

A big thank you to all our artists, writers and advertisers who continue to support and encourage the work we do at Arts Illustrated, helping us move forward with grace and humility in this journey.

Vincent Adaikalraj



Editor's note

The five things you won't find in this issue:

- The five elements
- Anything to do with anything 'five' in religion
- The five Olympic rings
- The five senses
- The phrase 'High Five'

The five things you will find in this issue:

- Openness
- Inclusivity
- Quirkiness
- Unpredictability
- Dialogue

So please do read, yes?



Praveena Shivram
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Cover Artist



Don't hold the movement of time. Instead, give it more speed (translated Bengali proverb)

I graduated from the Government College of Art and Crafts in 1984. I was extensively trained in the craft of realistic painting, as was the tradition of the typical Bengal school style in my college. I continued to make realistic works for almost three decades after completing my formal education, although I always had the urge to break away from the formal qualities of the recognisable. Only in 2004 did I produce my first body of abstract works. For me, what the eye sees is represented in realistic works, but abstraction is the voice of the soul. It involves a lot of emotion and sensitivity to sentiments. The process is that of giving form to our innermost feelings – the formless.

All my abstract works associate with a time of the day (or night). All life around us moves in a ritualistic way. The environment around us changes by the minute and that has a direct bearing on our emotions and thought processes. My abstract works are an endeavour to express these very emotions, of a moment in time. My thoughts are manifested into a form, but I allow my viewers to interpret the renditioning. There are no rules in doing that.

For the cover of the fifth anniversary issue of Arts Illustrated, I chose to create a work titled 'Five A.M.' I have used five colours in the work to interpret this time that is a sacred moment of transition from night to day, from stillness to action.



Sudip Roy

Cover design and sub-covers
curated by Rahul Kumar.



Cinema Q & A

The Fifth Taste of Privilege

Peter Svatek's documentary 'Theatre of Life' follows the journey of Chef Bottura's work as enabler featuring the setting up of Refettorio Ambrosiano in Milan in 2015 and how food can become central to the distinction between privilege and influence.

SARITHA RAO RAYACHOTI

For the theme of '5', an article on The Five Ages of Parmigiano Reggiano would have been a clever fit. Created by eminent chef Massimo Bottura back in 1995 at Osteria Francescana, his Michelin 3-Star restaurant in Modena, Italy, the dish is an ode to Parmigiano Reggiano, and uses the cheese, aged for different durations, cooked in different techniques and served in five different textures in one dish. Parmigiano Reggiano itself evokes the intensely savoury fifth flavour – umami. The dish expectedly raises the bar on decadence by involving the five senses of taste, smell, sight, touch, with a lesser emphasis on sound (Chef Bottura has famously used

sound to great effect for a New York Times video, where in a sound-proof studio, he wordlessly cooked and served his lasagna with ragu and pasta crackers to a robot, and then added a cheeky twist.) Pushing the boundaries of gastronomic experience, with an aesthete's eye and a touch of playfulness is what Chef Bottura does best.

It could have been a clever fit, if there wasn't more to explore. And so, instead of a link to the theme, I found a springboard through Chef Bottura's work as enabler, captured in an insightful documentary called *Theatre of Life* (2016) by Peter Svatek that featured the setting

up of Refettorio Ambrosiano in Milan in 2015.

The Refettorio Ambrosiano is a soup kitchen that served ingenious meals from available food waste ingredients for the poor, the homeless and the refugees in Milan and, interestingly, cooked by some of the most talented and renowned chefs in the world. At its heart, the Refettorio Ambrosiano is a stunningly simple idea, but replete with the logistical complexity that requires someone of Chef Bottura's stature, who is very aware of his influence and is conscious about how he channels it. But this is not about charity, as Chef Bottura puts it. It's about a



Photograph credit: Caritas Ambrosiana.

culture where there is no dichotomy between frugality and hospitality. ‘If you think about it, chefs are under the spotlight,’ said Chef Bottura over an e-mail interview. ‘They are influencers; therefore, they have the responsibility to go outside their kitchens and help their communities to grow and become more sustainable and united. But the point is that it is not only about chefs. Anyone has a voice, and anyone can use it – a baker, a student, an activist, whoever. We can all make the difference’.

From the day it opened until February 2018, the Refettorio Ambrosiano has served 69,000 meals created from 20 tons of recovered food ingredients such as browned bananas, stale bread and overripe tomatoes. Including Refettorio’s resident kitchen team, there have been 60 chefs involved in creating meals, enabled by 93 volunteers. The Refettorio Ambrosiano is important not just for the idea at its core but also because it sowed the seeds of what would go on to become ‘Food for Soul’, a non-profit to promote social

awareness about food wastage and hunger.

The Refettorio Ambrosiano, and the Refettorios that came after, utilise abandoned or under-utilised spaces that are transformed into halls with communal tables, with art and design playing a role beyond the functional. ‘Beauty is a universal language. This is why it is so important in our projects – as well as anywhere. The surrounding environment makes a huge difference in the perception of the experience you’re living. This is what I’ve learned from more than 20 years at my restaurant, where design, as much as art and music, are essential ingredients for the meal we serve to our customers. Art and design at the Refettorios play exactly the same role: they push our guests to a more holistic approach to nourishment – to feed the body and the soul,’ explained Chef Bottura.

Recognising the nuanced definition of this endeavour, film-maker Peter Svatek captured in his documentary not only

Chef Bottura’s vision but also the manner in which the Refettorio gained momentum with some of the world’s best chefs stepping in to cook meals in its kitchen. Importantly, the documentary also trails six patrons – Stefi, Marco, Fawaz, Fatou, Giorgio and Christiana – for whom the Refettorio became a space of inclusion, even as they savoured wholesome, exquisitely plated meals created by famous chefs they had perhaps never heard of.

In an e-mail interview, Peter Svatek recounts his journey as a documentary film-maker, and his choice and exploration of the subjects he chooses to depict. And in one instructive moment, as I read Peter Svatek’s response on the distinction between privilege and influence, I realised that the work of Chef Bottura through Food for Soul, and that of Peter Svatek through Theatre of Life are not merely about bridging the chasm between want and need. They are really about one’s circle of influence, and enabling the world from within it.



Photograph credit: Peter Svatek.

Excerpts from the interview

I find your choice of subjects for your documentaries intriguing. What draws you to the people and the themes of your documentaries?

Contradiction. Grey zones to explore.

In *Stolen Babies, Stolen Lives* (2008), I was drawn to the children brought up by the murderers of their parents – who discovered the truth of their upbringing as adolescents and yet continued to love the ‘parents’ they knew, who had brought them up with love (despite being some of Argentina’s Dirty War’s worst criminals – rapists, murderers, torturers). I wanted to share their extraordinary experience, not judge it. The film is not about politics. It is about human identity. It asks the question, what would you do if as a teenager you found out everything you know about yourself is a lie?

To do *Takedown: The DNA of GSP* (2014), I had to get past my distaste for the Ultimate Fighting Championship (UFC) in general. But I found Georges St-Pierre (GSP) a fascinating human being. Firstly, he is supremely talented. A world champion. Amazing ability. Amazing discipline. Amazing endurance. I discovered the heart and soul that comprises Mixed Martial Arts (MMA) competition. Georges sees himself as a samurai, a warrior, in the spiritual sense. He wants to live life by its code. Almost a soldier’s credo. And he partially succeeds and partially fails, as we all do. The violence of his sport is built into its DNA. That both troubled and fascinated me. Those contradictions drew me in.

The film is a portrait of Georges, not MMA, nor the UFC.

Theatre of Life offered the chance to examine two opposite and almost opposing worlds – celebrity chefs and what makes them tick, and the refugees and homeless people they served at the Refettorio – and what makes them tick. And the profoundly interesting lives of Stefi and Marco and Fawaz and Fatou and Giorgio and Christiana; I wondered what that encounter would bring. I believe it also offers a small meditation on the fuller meaning of food. Massimo told me a shared meal is man’s most ancient social occasion. That is deeply interesting. A Refettorio is more than a food hall, it strives to also be a place of encounter and peace and solace. I tried to follow that thread as well.

Documentary, by its very nature, is a reactive medium and the scenes that find their way into the final cut are unscripted. When filming ends and you have all this footage to sift through, the challenge is in selecting the parts to narrate a larger story. Which scenes of Theatre of Life were spontaneous and unexpectedly ended up enriching the entire narrative?

I reject that dichotomy. I do believe in reaction as creation. At a certain point in my life, I lost the fascination with my own ideas. I became interested in making films as an exploration, and to some degree at the service of the story of others. That said, I am not afraid of invention. So your question is delicate. Off the top of my head I’d say everything in my films is reactive. Also, I choose to keep myself out of my films, despite being a participant by making them. Being filmed



Fawaz Naser, Photograph credit: Peter Svatek.



Photograph credit: Caritas Ambrosiana.



Photograph credit: Caritas Ambrosiana.



Photograph credit: Peter Svatek.



Massimo Bottura, Peter Svatek, Giancarlo Migliore and Nicolas Venne on camera and Nicola Baragaglia on sound.
Photograph credit: Peter Svatek.

changes the subject. I am part of that. To deny that is folly. I try to follow what I can see of the reality of the film's subjects. Sometimes that leads me to a kind of creation with them. But I avoid falseness as best I am able to. The line between documentary and fiction is fascinating.

In the documentary, Chef Massimo Bottura quotes Bob Dylan's 'Like a Rolling Stone'. The song, with its theme of home is a recurring motif in the film. Was this intentional from the start or did it evolve during the film-making process?

That is the perfect example of my previous answer. The idea was entirely Massimo's, although he had no idea I wanted to use it in the film until he saw the completed film. I was filming him speaking to students about the upcoming Refettorio and he mentioned being asked to do something culinary for the 50th anniversary of 'Like a Rolling Stone'. That inspired me to listen to the song again. I found its words and music very relevant to the film. So I began to look for ways to make it more central to the film than just that mention by Massimo. That ended up involving my interactions with Marco and Stefi, as well as Massimo.

There are experiences that redefine an idea or concept for us, something beyond the known, opening us to a newer deeply satisfying way of experiencing life. I call it the Umami Moment. Did you have moments like that during the filming that redefined some long-held perceptions?

The biggest reason I moved from fiction to documentary was because of wanting to move from the notion of struggling to externalise an idea of my own on to the screen, to liberating myself to follow an idea outside of myself. In other words, to explore. Or, another way of putting it, to journey. Instead of trying to cram my idea into

film, I am trying to empty myself enough to follow something wherever it leads me. And surviving that journey to end up somewhere hopefully universal enough and clear enough to communicate. That is very satisfying.

What do the Refettorio Ambrosiano and Chef Massimo Bottura evoke in you about the use of privilege and influence to create a conversation, and the power of ideas in social inclusion?

I think social inclusion means listening more than speaking. Being more than judging. I am not against ideas. I enjoy them and occasionally have a few. It's delicate. Social organisation needs both structure and leadership. Genius needs room to grow. Privilege is largely irrelevant to that. Although not entirely. But the human condition creates both privilege and its opposite. Massimo may be part and parcel of privilege, but I do believe the real value to him and to me and to the audience of his Refettorio experiment did not come from that privilege. The money did – both for the Refettorio and indirectly (because of the fame of the celebrity chefs) for the budget of the film.

I'd like to elaborate on the role of privilege, both in my film and in general. This is a striking moment in history to discuss the power and potential for evil of privilege. It depends a little on the broadness of your definition of privilege. There is a president in the United States who seems to view privilege as a goal. The

positive result of the American dream. Wealth. Possession. Money. And, especially, power over others. There are fundamentalist strains in all the major religions – Muslim, Hindu, Christian, Buddhist, Jewish – that associate privilege as illegitimate, but attributing it solely to the 'other'. There are also powerful movements attributing the evil of privilege to other major aspects of life – sexual power and politics, race, access to education, the environment, the Internet, the corporate world, and many other things. My point is that privilege is often blamed and yet it is a result of the human condition. It's the whipping boy of frustration. Blame the other, especially the other who impoverishes you. What has all that got to do with my film? I consider myself and Massimo privileged – by any ordinary definition of privilege. There is a facile view that the Refettorio was just a bunch of rich fame-seeking chefs out to polish their own stars. And me as their lackey. There is of course some truth to that. But not a lot. That ultimately leads nowhere.

I felt Rene Redzepi had the best answer in the film. I'll stop talking and listen, leaving the final word to him. 'I understand that people say you should go back to your kitchen and shut up. But that's bullshit. Because everybody should do something. It's a simple gesture. And it belongs to everybody, the responsibility to take care of other people that are in dire straits.'



Photograph credit: Emanuele Colombo.



Photograph credit: Caritas Ambrosiana.



Peter Svatek.



